Whole-book QA: Prologue through Chapter 15

2026-11-07 14:31 UTC. Desks: the Reader Panel (`gw-panel`) and the Anti-Slop Reader (`gw-slopreader`), dispatched in parallel, read-only. Flow figures were counted by script; the voice rules by `scripts/voice_check.py`. No prose was changed.

What was covered. Of 28 planned chapters, 15 are refined, plus the Prologue and Introduction. Parts I (River) and II (Oak) are complete. Part III (Sun) is missing its closing chapter, Ch16 *Warmth Is Strength*, which has not been started. So the Sun-arc findings say what Ch16 must carry. They do not say the arc is flat.

Where everything is: - the ledger of suggestions, the master copy: `runs/qa/2026-11-07-edits-ch00-`

`ch15.json`, 114 items; - the review table, generated from the ledger: `runs/qa/2026-11-07-edits-ch00-ch15.md`; - the desk reports: `runs/qa/2026-11-07-panel-ch00-ch15.md` and `runs/qa/2026-11-07-slop-ch00-ch15.md`; - the flow counts: `runs/qa/2026-11-07-readability-ch00-ch15.json`.

The back-of-book check

`python3 scripts/practice_sync.py --book`: `RESULT: PASS on 15 chapter(s)`. The appendix matches every chapter.

The counted rules (`voice_check.py`, HARD

checks)

Prologue

Result: FAIL you-density: 61 in 1989 = 30.7 per 1,000 (floor 40)

Introduction

Result: FAIL you-density: 29 in 969 = 29.9 per 1,000 (floor 40)

Ch1

Result: FAIL you-density: 67 in 2030 = 33.0 per 1,000 (floor 40)

Ch2

Result: FAIL em-dash: 1 in prose (cap 0)

Ch7

Result: pass; REVIEW: “That’s not X. That’s Y.” reframe x3 (cap 2)

Ch3–6, Ch8–15

Result: all HARD checks passed

Flow and reading level (counted)

Prologue

Avg words/sentence: 11.4

Sentences ≤6 words: 27%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 4%

Reading grade (FK): 4.3

“I” per 100 words: 3.9

Introduction

Avg words/sentence: 10.5

Sentences ≤6 words: 23%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 41%

Reading grade (FK): 5.7

“I” per 100 words: 0.0

Ch1

Avg words/sentence: 9.0

Sentences ≤6 words: 42%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 22%

Reading grade (FK): 3.7

“I” per 100 words: 2.6

Ch2

Avg words/sentence: 8.3

Sentences ≤6 words: 45%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 35%

Reading grade (FK): 3.9

“I” per 100 words: 0.1

Ch3

Avg words/sentence: 8.4

Sentences ≤6 words: 44%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 35%

Reading grade (FK): 4.2

“I” per 100 words: 0.3

Ch4

Avg words/sentence: 8.6

Sentences ≤6 words: 46%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 38%

Reading grade (FK): 4.6

“I” per 100 words: 0.1

Ch5

Avg words/sentence: 9.2

Sentences ≤6 words: 50%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 38%

Reading grade (FK): 4.4

“I” per 100 words: 0.8

Ch6

Avg words/sentence: 11.6

Sentences ≤6 words: 24%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 37%

Reading grade (FK): 5.0

“I” per 100 words: 0.5

Ch7

Avg words/sentence: 12.2

Sentences ≤6 words: 25%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 29%

Reading grade (FK): 5.6

“I” per 100 words: 0.2

Ch8

Avg words/sentence: 11.5

Sentences ≤6 words: 21%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 23%

Reading grade (FK): 4.9

“I” per 100 words: 0.3

Ch9

Avg words/sentence: 10.0

Sentences ≤6 words: 34%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 36%

Reading grade (FK): 4.9

“I” per 100 words: 0.1

Ch10

Avg words/sentence: 11.6

Sentences ≤6 words: 30%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 26%

Reading grade (FK): 4.6

“I” per 100 words: 0.3

Ch11

Avg words/sentence: 11.4

Sentences ≤6 words: 15%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 19%

Reading grade (FK): 5.3

“I” per 100 words: 0.8

Ch12

Avg words/sentence: 11.4

Sentences ≤6 words: 27%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 19%

Reading grade (FK): 4.3

“I” per 100 words: 2.1

Ch13

Avg words/sentence: 11.9

Sentences ≤6 words: 16%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 20%

Reading grade (FK): 4.7

“I” per 100 words: 0.0

Ch14

Avg words/sentence: 12.5

Sentences ≤6 words: 19%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 28%

Reading grade (FK): 5.1

“I” per 100 words: 2.0

Ch15

Avg words/sentence: 11.1

Sentences ≤6 words: 24%

Paragraphs ≤12 words: 14%

Reading grade (FK): 4.2

“I” per 100 words: 3.1

How these were counted: the syllable count is a heuristic, so read the grade as relative between chapters, not as an absolute. The Flesch-Kincaid grade is between 3.7 and 5.7 everywhere, so **difficulty is not the problem; rhythm is.** Ch1–5 is the fragment-heavy block. Part II is mixed: Ch9 is the most choppy chapter after Ch5. The “I” column counts the author’s own presence on the page.

Do the later chapters read better?

Both desks say yes, and that it is not about sentence length alone. The Anti-Slop Reader names seven differences. In Ch1–5:

1. fragment chains leave the reader to rebuild the cause;

2. a punchline ends nearly every paragraph;
3. “Not X. Not Y.” negation stacks;
4. the wife appears as weather or as a system;
5. the triggers are generic;
6. “most men” is used as a foil;
7. mechanism nouns (“activation state”, “updated her model”).

The Panel adds the author’s own presence. “I” appears 0.1–0.8 times per 100 words in Ch2–11, against 2.0–3.1 in Ch12, 14 and 15. It also counts 20 “most/some/many men” lines from the Prologue to Ch10, and none in Ch11–15.

Ch11 is the exception: a late chapter that reads worse. It is procedural, its warmth review said “not yet”, and none of that review’s fixes have been applied.

Keep, both desks agree: - the named handles: the Three-Second Window, the Four

D’s, the view from above, care without contagion; - the anchor images: fence and nails, the kicked dog, the soup; - the closes of Ch1, Ch2 and Ch4.

The Anti-Slop Reader’s phrase is “Bring Ch1–5 forward, not down.”

The later chapters have their own habits: - instructional beat labels (Ch11, Ch13–15); - a stock research-caveat sentence, repeated across Ch12–15; - “Chapter N covers…” pointers; - the “You can A and still B” shape, used four times in Ch11.

What the early chapters need. Both desks agree on a line-level pass on Ch1–5, roughly 25 to 40 edits per chapter, with no structural change. The Panel adds one first-person story each for Ch3, Ch4 and Ch5. Those have to come from an author interview and must not be invented.

Ranked: the ten most damaging

1 · Prologue L17 vs Ch14 L13 · both

ID: Q001

What: Prologue: “both of us working full time the whole time”. Ch14: a three-year sabbatical. Factual contradiction.

Fix cost: small, needs your facts

2 · Prologue L35–39, Ch1 L77–89, Ch2 L60–68 · Panel

ID: Q002

What: The armor mistake, the book’s central reveal, is told in full twice before Ch16, which is planned to tell it again.

Fix cost: medium, your call

3 · Ch1–5 · both

ID: Q003/Q004

What: The register gap described above.

Fix cost: large: a line pass plus an interview for Ch3–5

4 · Ch1 L71 vs Ch8 L39, Ch15 L43 · Panel

ID: Q005

What: Ch1 says to keep the “best husband” question for afterward; Ch8 and Ch15 use it in the moment.

Fix cost: small, one sentence in Ch1

5 · Ch4 L63 · Anti-Slop (high) vs Panel (keep)

ID: Q006

What: “Anger isn’t strength. It’s the absence of it.”

Fix cost: **The desks disagree; your call**

6 · Ch10 L147 · both

ID: Q007

What: “You hold it anyway.” straight after the safety sentence reads as “stay in harm’s way”.

Fix cost: small, move one line

7 · Ch14 L29 · both

ID: Q008

What: “Men tend to think…” is a universal claim about men, and the logic doesn’t follow.

Fix cost: small

8 · Ch15 L23 · both

ID: Q009

What: “says less about you” lets a defensive reader dismiss her, and contradicts Ch3 L73.

Fix cost: small

9 · Ch16 (planned) · Panel

ID: Q010

What: Ch16 must carry her words once, the cost, the turn, the “river without the sun” callback, and the close of Part III.

Fix cost: goes into the Ch16 interview

10 · Part II (Ch6–8, Ch11) · Panel

ID: —

What: Ch6–8 cover the ledger ground three times; Part II has no closing beat.

Fix cost: medium

Where the desks disagree (both readings kept)

The ledger has 17 items where the two desks rate the same line at different severities or recommend different fixes. The review table shows both, separated by **OR**. The main ones:
- **Ch4 L63.** The Anti-Slop Reader rates “Anger isn’t strength. It’s the absence of it.”

high: it contradicts the chapter's own account of anger as involuntary. The Panel recommends keeping the author's line, as it does for Ch2 L78 and Ch12 L81. - **The study caveats in Ch12–15.** The Panel's Paul and the tension reader want one sentence per study, with the caveats moved to endnotes. Eric dissents: he wants the evidence on the page. - **Softening Part I.** Eric wants it. Paul dissents: Part I's diagnostic edge is what he needs.

Earlier reports: what is still open

- **Inbox #101's 18-line backlog:** 17 items still present, 1 fixed (the Ch12 forgiveness line). - **The 2026-09-23 structural findings:** mostly fixed. Fixed are Ch8's real-unfairness answer, the old chronology, the broken callbacks, the Ch12 reciprocity promise and the Introduction's sixth failure mode. - **The 2026-**

10-02 warmth reviews: Ch11, 12 and 13 unapplied; Ch14 largely applied.

Not covered

- The OKF, plates and PDFs were not read. - No sources were checked. The four items marked for the Fact-Checker in the ledger are unchecked. - Parts IV and V are not written.

Edit suggestions, Prologue to Ch15

Generated 2026-11-07 from `runs/qa/2026-11-07-edits-ch00-ch15.json`. Do not edit this file: rule on items by ID and the JSON records it. Regenerated wholesale.

114 suggestions. 10 high, 49 medium, 55 low. 32 raised by both desks. 17 where the desks disagree (both fixes shown). Every quoted line was checked against the current prose.

How to rule: reply with IDs, e.g. *accept Q012 Q015, reject Q020, Q005 use panel's fix*. Anything with **OR** needs you to pick one.

1. Your decisions first

35 items: they need your facts, your ruling, or a choice between two desks.

Q001 · Prol L17 · HIGH

Problem: The Prologue says both always worked full time; Ch14 says she has been on a three-year sabbatical as a full-time mother.

Proposed: panel: Author to confirm the timeline; likely ’both of us working full time for most of it, from diapers up through a house full of teenagers.’ **OR** *slopreader:* Author to confirm, then: ’both of us working full time for most of it’.

Q003 · Ch1 to Ch5 · HIGH

Problem: The early chapters read worse than Ch12-15 because of fragment chains carrying explanation, near-zero author presence, ’most men’ foils and closing verdict lines, not sentence length alone.

Proposed: Revision pass: rejoin fragment chains in explanatory passages (e.g., Ch2 L38, Ch4 L59) into sentences and keep one hit per

section; cut the foils; drop about half of the ’---’ dividers in Ch2-5; keep Part I’s diagnostic edge.

Q004 · Ch1 to Ch5 · HIGH

Problem: The early chapters run on fragment chains, ’Not X. Not Y.’ stacks and a punchline at the end of nearly every paragraph; that, more than length, is why readers prefer Ch11-15.

Proposed: Per chapter: merge fragment chains into one sentence with the link stated; cut paragraph-ending aphorisms except the chapter’s one turn; turn ’most men’ into ’you’; add one sentence of her side; keep the Window, the Four D’s, the fence parable, the soup scene and the Ch1/Ch2/Ch4 closes. Samples are in Part 1.

Q005 · Ch1 L71 · HIGH

Problem: Ch1 reserves the ’best husband’ question for afterward, but Ch8 and Ch15 use it mid-moment as ’Chapter 1’s question’.

Proposed: Add after L71: ’Some nights the long question fits in one breath too: *Am I being the best husband I can be right now?* Ask it that way in the moment if it comes. Save the four checks for later.’ (needs the author’s word; Ch1 is accepted prose)

Q006 · Ch4 L63 · HIGH

Problem: Still present from inbox 101; a verdict that contradicts the chapter’s own account of anger as an involuntary first motion.

*Proposed: slopreader: ’*Anger feels like strength. The strength Marcus meant is what you do with it.’ **OR** *panel:* KEEP the author’s line as written; earlier reports disagreed and the panel recommends not averaging them.

Q008 · Ch14 L29 · HIGH

Problem: The logic doesn’t follow, and it reads as a dig.

Proposed: panel: But the woman they’re comparing her to is someone they’ve never lived with, so it’s just a dream. **OR** *slopreader:* Replace the three sentences with: ’It’s easy to picture a better life with someone else. It’s easy to picture because you’ve never had to live it.’

Q009 · Ch15 L23 · HIGH

Problem: Gives a defensive reader licence to treat every complaint as her mood, and contradicts Ch3’s ’she has the outside view of your behavior’.

Proposed: panel: Often the remark says as much about her day as it does about you. **OR** *slopreader:* ’It shows you how she’s feeling.’

Q010 · Ch16 · HIGH

Problem: Ch16 must close Part III by giving what the Prologue and Ch1 have not: her words once, duration, cost, the turn, and the oak-plus-sun integration.

Proposed: Spec Ch16 to carry: her actual words once (author interview); what it cost and how he got back; the ’river without the sun’ callback; the compassion distinction promised by inbox 146; a Part III close with a bridge to the Desert; no one-line imperative ending.

Q011 · book · med

Problem: River, oak and sun are almost absent from chapter prose: the oak never appears, the sun appears once in Ch15, which breaks the elements-only-in-preambles rule.

Proposed: Author ruling: allow one explicit element line per Part (then Ch10 takes ’The

oak holds firm’ and Ch16 calls back the Introduction’s ’The river without the sun becomes detached’), or cut Ch15’s sun line.

Q014 · Prol · med

Problem: Counted voice rule: you-density 30.7 per 1,000 (floor 40).

Proposed: Line Editor fix to bring the count inside the rule; for the Prologue/Introduction you-density, author ruling on whether memoir register is exempt.

Q016 · Prol L41 · med

Problem: A universal claim that sorts men morally (backlog, still present).

Proposed: panel: I’ve needed help with things that mattered. **OR** *slopreader:* ’I’ve needed help with every hard thing I’ve gotten good at.’

Q017 · Prol L43 · med

Problem: A verdict after a diagnosis of inherited expectations (backlog, still present).

Proposed: panel: Without that effort, the habits you already have keep deciding for you. **OR** *slopreader:* Delete from ’A lot of men skip…’ through ’was actually good at this.’ and delete ’Skipping it is the easy way out.’; keep ’It takes real effort, sustained over years.’

Q018 · Intro · med

Problem: Counted voice rule: you-density 29.9 per 1,000 (floor 40).

Proposed: Line Editor fix to bring the count inside the rule; for the Prologue/Introduction you-density, author ruling on whether memoir register is exempt.

Q019 · Ch1 · med

Problem: Counted voice rule: you-density 33.0 per 1,000 (floor 40).

Proposed: Line Editor fix to bring the count inside the rule; for the Prologue/Introduction you-density, author ruling on whether memoir register is exempt.

Q026 · Ch2 L52 · med

Problem: An invented crowd of lesser men as a foil (backlog, still present).

Proposed: panel: Notice whether your calm depends on everyone else being calm. **OR** *slopreader:* ’A peaceful house can feel like character when it’s really just timing.’

Q028 · Ch2 L78 · med

Problem: Still present: a verdict that repeats what line 76 already says.

Proposed: slopreader: Delete line 78. **OR** *panel:* KEEP the author’s line as written;

earlier reports disagreed and the panel recommends not averaging them.

Q030 · Ch3 to Ch5 · med

Problem: Ch3, Ch4 and Ch5 have no story from the author's own marriage, which is what makes Ch12-15 read better.

Proposed: Inbox item for an author interview: one first-person specific each for defensiveness (Ch3), anger (Ch4) and coming back after a fight (Ch5). Do not invent.

Q031 · Ch3 L57 · med

Problem: Negative social proof (backlog, still present).

Proposed: panel: Waiting in dread leaves you unprepared. **OR** *slopreader:* 'Waiting in dread doesn't prepare you for anything.'

Q032 · Ch3 L95 · med

Problem: Casts her as the scorekeeper the book later takes apart, and closes on a threat.

Proposed: panel: She's been noticing longer than you know. **OR** *slopreader: '*She can tell, and she's been able to tell for longer than you know.'

Q033 · Ch5 L15 · med

Problem: Contagion-as-invasion framing (backlog, still present).

Proposed: panel: The mood you picked up before the conversation began. **OR** *slopreader: '*The mood you picked up before the conversation began.'

Q040 · Ch7 L25 · med

Problem: Pillemer's interview pool is described differently in Ch10.

Proposed: panel: people who'd been married thirty years or more (Fact-Checker to confirm)

OR *panel:* Name the study, or cut it to [PLACEHOLDER: 13-year 7,000-couple study, source] for the Fact-Checker. **OR** *slopreader:* ’It’s the pattern that shows up when long marriages describe themselves looking backward.’

Q042 · Ch8 L15 · med

Problem: ’Traditional’ mislabels the husband’s example (backlog, still present).

Proposed: panel: You might earn less and do more of the work at home. **OR** *slopreader:* ’The shape of what’s underneath varies from marriage to marriage. You might earn less and do more of the work at home.’

Q045 · Ch9 L47 · med

Problem: The four questions that follow are not Ch1’s four, and they come in a different order.

Proposed: panel: So run the four checks from Chapter 1, aimed at speaking up. **OR** *slopreader:* Delete the sentence.

Q046 · Ch10 L60 · med

Problem: Windup plus negative social proof (backlog, still present).

Proposed: panel: Delete L60-61; begin ’Naming it changes the argument you have with your wife.’ **OR** *slopreader:* Merge 60-61: ’Naming it also changes the argument you have with your wife.’

Q049 · Ch11 L37 · med

Problem: The decade she carried the income is used only for his self-denial, with no word of thanks to her.

Proposed: Add one sentence of thanks in the author’s own words: [AUTHOR: one line on what her carrying that decade meant].

Q053 · Ch12 to Ch15 · med

Problem: The same research-caveat sentence recurs across four chapters and reads like a methods section.

Proposed: Keep one caveat per chapter as a clause before the finding; author to rule on dropping one of Ch14's four studies (for example Froh, line 21, since the kids' story carries that point).

Q054 · Ch12 L15 · med

Problem: Contradicts Ch1's careful account of what the author inherited (the sulk and the cutting sentence, not the yelling).

Proposed: panel: He's also the man whose temper ran down through my family. **OR** *slopreader:* 'He's also the man whose temper ran down through my family.'

Q055 · Ch12 L77 · med

Problem: An unsourced empirical claim plus a garbled research clause, in front of an evidence-oriented reader.

Proposed: panel: Fact-Checker to source it or make it [PLACEHOLDER: source]; otherwise state it as the author's observation: 'In long marriages, the danger usually isn't that the fighting starts. It's that the warmth stops.' Cut the 'travel together' clause or name the study. **OR** *slopreader:* 'Partners who feel appreciated also tend to show more appreciation, though the research can't say which comes first.'

Q058 · Ch15 L5 · med

Problem: Ch15 opens with the principle and then a table of contents.

Proposed: Open with line 7 ('She says something with an edge…'), keep 'Warmth is easy on a good day. It gets tested on the

ordinary ones.’ as the orientation after it, and delete ’Each one has an answer: …’

Q059 · Ch15 L41 · med

Problem: Management-deck filler.

Proposed: slopreader: ’When I let the zings go and give her kindness instead, the whole house gets lighter.’ **OR** *slopreader:* Delete both sentences; at 47 ’…everybody’s pulled into the vortex’ becomes ’…everybody ends up in it’; at 49 ’Warmth is how you stay out of it and help her out of it.’

Q067 · Ch2 · low

Problem: Counted voice rule: em-dash: 1 in prose (cap 0).

Proposed: Line Editor fix to bring the count inside the rule; for the Prologue/Introduction you-density, author ruling on whether memoir register is exempt.

Q083 · Ch7 · low

Problem: Counted voice rule: ’That’s not X. That’s Y.’ reframe x3 (cap 2), REVIEW.

Proposed: Line Editor fix to bring the count inside the rule; for the Prologue/Introduction you-density, author ruling on whether memoir register is exempt.

Q100 · Ch12 L37 · low

Problem: Reads as a transaction and has to be walked back at L51; the reports disagree (persona report: the author’s chosen language; warmth review: change it).

Proposed: Author decision; the warmth option is ’Romance is showing your wife she’s still chosen.’

Q107 · Ch14 to Ch15 · low

Problem: By Ch15 the reader holds a verbatim file of the wife’s complaints (’hoarders’, ’very

anxious', the Saturday lines), and the wife will read the book.

Proposed: Author to confirm that the disclosure boundary covers Ch14-15 as written; no edit without his word.

Q112 · Ch14 L53 · low

Problem: Unclear whether the Avatar gesture is the remedy for hollow thanks or one more ritual.

Proposed: Author to clarify; likely 'A quick thanks can land hollow, like an "I love you" said with nothing behind it. The fingertip and "I see you" are how we try to mean it.'

2. Structural and cross-chapter

15 items: larger passes, mostly a revision plan, not single line edits.

Q012 · book · med

Problem: Marcus gets his private-notebook biography in five chapters, Epictetus his in three, and the dichotomy of control is explained from scratch four times.

Proposed: After the first chapter, one clause of identification, never repeated in the same words (e.g. ’Marcus Aurelius, the emperor whose private notes became the Meditations’). Keep Ch1’s full Marcus paragraph and Ch2’s Epictetus line.

Q013 · book · med

Problem: Five chapters open on ’There’s/There are a [thing] you didn’t choose or notice.’

Proposed: Vary Ch3: ’When she criticizes you, your answer is ready before she’s finished, and you never chose it. You learned it.’ Ch13: ’You can give your wife an evening

and still not give her your attention, and the difference is small enough to miss for years.’

Q015 · Prol to Ch1 · med

Problem: The disappearance story is told in full in both the Prologue and Ch1, and both lift lines from the voice spec’s own example.

Proposed: Prologue 37: ’She noticed before I did, and she was right. Nothing I was doing looked bad from the outside. From inside the marriage, it was a slow quiet distance she couldn’t name and I wouldn’t admit to.’

Q024 · Ch2 to Ch5 to Ch8 · med

Problem: Still present: three recap openings across Parts I-II.

Proposed: Ch8: ’You’ve done something for the family, and a small criticism is still bothering you days later.’ Ch5: ’You’re already inside a real fight, and everything

from the last four chapters gets used at once.’ Ch2: ’Something has been deciding how you feel when you walk through your own door, and you never signed off on it.’

Q038 · Ch6 to Ch8 · med

Problem: Ch6-8 each close or near-close on a forward pointer instead of an image.

Proposed: Ch6: move ’Scorekeeping can feed resentment… can’t sustain.’ to the end of ’The paradox’ beat, delete the pointer, and close on ’One of them is steady enough to be counted on without needing to be counted.’ Ch8: delete line 57.

Q044 · Ch9 to Ch15 · med

Problem: Four of the last seven chapters end on the same one-line ’when X, do Y’ imperative.

Proposed: Vary at least Ch13 and Ch15 (see their items) so that each closes on its own image.

Q048 · Ch11 to Ch15 · med

Problem: The later chapters use instructional beat labels; the archetype asks for evocative ones.

Proposed: For example, Ch11: ’What needs your attention.’ / ’Hardship without shutting down.’ / ’The rule you disagree with.’ / ’The postponed conversation.’ / ’Say it, then listen.’ Ch13: ’The time you share.’ / ’Still learning her.’ Ch14: ’What you value.’ / ’Before you need it.’ / ’Watering it.’ Ch15’s triad may stay as its named structure.

Q056 · Ch13 to Ch15 · med

Problem: Study inserts with caveats cool the later chapters just as they warm up, the one place the later voice is weaker.

Proposed: One sentence per study, caveats to the endnotes. For example, Ch13 L57: ’Tsapelas, Aron and Orbuch followed married couples for sixteen years; those who found the marriage boring in year seven were less satisfied nine years later.’

Q060 · book · low

Problem: Citation and typography style drifts between chapters.

Proposed: One mechanical pass: pick one numeral style and one translator-credit form, normalize quotes, unwrap Ch10.

Q061 · book · low

Problem: ’Tuesday’ is the default day across the book.

Proposed: Vary the day in Ch6 L35, Ch10 L105 and Ch10 L256.

Q062 · book · low

Problem: ’Tuesday’ is the stock ordinary day in seven chapters.

Proposed: Keep Ch1 and Ch6 3; vary the others, for example Ch10 256 ’on a weeknight when you were already finished at four’, Ch2 50 ’They can change any day without warning.’

Q068 · Ch2 to Ch10 · low

Problem: Nearly word for word the same as Ch2 5’s biography line.

Proposed: Ch10: ’Epictetus, a former slave who became a teacher, left a short handbook called the *Enchiridion*.’

Q072 · Ch3 to Ch4 · low

Problem: Ch3 35 ’updated her model’ and Ch4 83 ’updated sense’ echo across consecutive chapters that both end at her withdrawing trust.

Proposed: Ch3 35: ’She remembers how hard it was to tell you.’ Ch4 83: ’Just a quieter sense of who she was dealing with.’

Q093 · Ch10 to Ch7 · low

Problem: An orphan paragraph, and it describes the Pillemer sample differently from Ch7.

Proposed: Fact-Checker to reconcile against the citation concept; move Ch10 82-84 to open ’What you do to each other’ or cut it.

Q110 · Ch14 to Ch15 · low

Problem: The identical pointer appears in Ch14 67 and Ch15 23.

Proposed: Ch15 23: ’If a remark still hurts you every time, tell her, the way you’d raise anything else that keeps coming back.’

3. Line edits, chapter by chapter

64 items: each is one line with replacement text. Most can be accepted in bulk per chapter.

Prol

Q002 · 37 · HIGH

Problem: The book’s central reveal (the armor mistake) is told in full and resolved in the Prologue, retold in Ch1 and re-corrected in Ch2, leaving Ch16 nothing new to reveal.

Replace with: Cut Prologue L36-39 to two sentences: ’Early on, I took one piece of the philosophy and ran it too far, and I started applying it to my wife. She noticed before I did, and I’ll tell you how in Chapter 16.’ Keep Ch1’s mechanism; save her words, duration and cost for Ch16.

Q063 · 33 · low

Problem: Windup; inbox 101 backlog item, still present.

Replace with: panel: Delete; begin L35. **OR** *slopreader:* Delete line 33 entirely; begin ’Early on, I took one piece of the philosophy and ran it too far.’

Q064 · 45 · low

Problem: An announcement sentence, and false: it comes late in the Prologue.

Replace with: Delete the sentence.

Q065 · 53 · low

Problem: The same phrase ends the Prologue and the Part I opener, which are read back to back.

Replace with: Change the Prologue to ’day by ordinary day’.

Ch1

Q020 · 5 · med

Problem: Dismisses her actual concern on page one of Ch1 (backlog, still present).

Replace with: panel: Before you answer the concern, notice what you're about to do with it. **OR** *slopreader:* 'What she said matters. What happens in the next three seconds matters first.'

Q021 · 13 · med

Problem: One of three competing thesis statements (Prologue: the armor mistake; Introduction: three qualities; Ch1: the window), and Part III is not about the window.

Replace with: That three-second window is where all of this starts.

Q022 · 73 · med

Problem: Makes a promise the book doesn't keep (the device is capped from Ch15) and uses 'unpack', a word on the audience file's avoid list.

Replace with: panel: You'll meet those four things again in the situations a marriage hands you. The replay question doesn't change. Neither does the breath. **OR** *slopreader:* 'The rest of this book takes those four things into every specific situation a marriage hands you.'

Q023 · 87 · med

Problem: Shifts to a third-person model husband and an inferior crowd at the chapter's turn.

Replace with: 'Stay reachable. Pause in the place you used to fire from. That pause takes more presence than distance ever could.'

Q066 · 19 · low

Problem: Windup (backlog, still present).

Replace with: panel: Delete. **OR** *slopreader:* Delete.

Ch2

Q025 · 10 · med

Problem: Misreads the quote: ’whatever are not our own acts’ plainly covers her mood, and a reader who knows the Enchiridion will catch it.

Replace with: Replace the paragraph with: ’Study that list. Her mood isn’t named on it. Not her state of mind. Not the energy she carries through the door. It falls under the last line, with whatever are not your own acts, because other people’s inner states were never yours to work with.’

Q027 · 64 · med

Problem: An orphaned echo of the removed De Ira quotation; it now answers nothing.

Replace with: Delete ’Not suppress. Not eliminate. *Calm.*’ and begin the paragraph ’The goal is not to stop feeling.’

Q029 · 80 · med

Problem: ’These’ has no antecedent for thirty lines, and the paragraph makes a third ending after L78.

Replace with: Her good days and her hard ones are things you prefer or don’t. Worth tending, every one of them.

Q069 · 38 · low

Problem: A fragment chain with clinical nouns, and two ’Nobody…pass it’ sentences in a row.

Replace with: Replace 38-40 with ’You came home carrying the day, and by bedtime the

whole house had it, down to a dog that did nothing. Nobody meant to pass it on. It didn’t stop until it ran out of people.’

Q070 · 46 · low

Problem: The only Marcus quotation not in the house’s Long translation.

Replace with: Fact-Checker to confirm whether Haines is an approved exception or swap to Long’s 6.8.

Ch3

Q071 · 35 · low

Problem: Analytical jargon where recognition belongs (backlog, still present).

Replace with: She just remembered how hard it was to tell you.

Ch4

Q073 · 43 · low

Problem: Clinical indirection (backlog, still present).

Replace with: panel: When you're both angry, you can say things neither of you meant to say. **OR** *slopreader:* 'But when you're both angry, you can say things neither of you meant to say.'

Q074 · 59 · low

Problem: Partly fixed; glossed twice, and 'lives' appears twice.

Replace with: 'That's where your *prohairesis* lives: your capacity to choose.'

Q075 · 61 · low

Problem: Repeats Ch1's framing of Marcus word for word.

Replace with: He was writing to himself, about what actual strength looks like.

Q076 · 79 · low

Problem: A ’most men’ foil in front of the chapter’s key line.

Replace with: Delete; keep ’An apology pulls the nail. It doesn’t fill the hole.’

Q077 · 93 · low

Problem: A second image stacked on the nail parable.

Replace with: Replace line 93 with ’You don’t need to find the nail behind each hole. You know what the hammer does, and you put it down.’

Ch5

Q034 · 37 · med

Problem: Repeats Ch4’s cold-anger lines almost word for word, in the next chapter.

Replace with: Cold anger, from the last chapter, is one. Not because you're cooling down, but because you want her to know.

Q035 · 65 · med

Problem: Third person in a second-person book: the reader watches a model husband (still present from the 2026-09-23 backlog).

Replace with: panel: When you come back to the unresolved conversation, wait until things are calm. (Continue L65-71 in second person.) **OR** *slopreader:* Rewrite 65-71 in second person: 'When you come back to the unresolved conversation, wait until things are calm. Ask if you can talk. Say what's true for you…'; line 71: 'You have a framework built on reason. Marriage doesn't run purely on reason, and she won't always get to an answer the way you do.'

Q078 · 19 · low

Problem: The heading keeps the nail image whose meaning changed, which the 2026-09-23 fix removed from the body.

Replace with: panel: **The trigger that lands on something tender. OR** *slopreader:* ’**The tender spot.**’

Q079 · 53 · low

Problem: Asserted without a source.

Replace with: Couples who make it fifty years don’t avoid fighting.

Ch6

Q036 · 9 · med

Problem: The dishes are hers in L9 but his in L11 and L13.

Replace with: until the dog walks belong to you and the laundry belongs to her

Q037 · 41 · med

Problem: Re-explains Ch3's Four D's in full, one Part later.

Replace with: Replace L41-43 with: 'When that verdict lands, the Four D's from Chapter 3 are right there: defend, deny, downplay, deflect. Each one feels justified, and each one turns a tired woman's comment about laundry into a trial over your character.' Keep L45-47.

Q080 · 11 · low

Problem: A windup plus an invented 'nobody'.

Replace with: Begin 'Once the split happens, you mostly stop seeing her half of it.'

Q081 · 13 · low

Problem: The coaching example is repeated in Ch7, where it is central.

Replace with: Delete the clause; end the sentence at ’running them through the wash.’

Q082 · 59 · low

Problem: The chapter’s last words are a signpost.

Replace with: Delete; end on ’Giving freely doesn’t mean carrying an arrangement you can’t sustain.’

Ch7

Q039 · 15 · med

Problem: Repeats the chapter’s own opening lines almost word for word.

Replace with: panel: Different currencies, same instinct, and you know where you stand in each the way you know your bank balance without checking it. **OR** *slopreader:* ’Different currencies, same instinct: you know

where you stand the way you know your bank balance without checking it.’

Q084 · 9 · low

Problem: Reuses Ch6’s ceiling fan in the next chapter.

Replace with: It’s just yours. Like the TV that needed a new setting after the last software update.

Q085 · 11 · low

Problem: A meta signpost.

Replace with: Delete.

Ch8

Q041 · 5 · med

Problem: A recap opening (the third in the book) that starts outside the reader’s

experience; unchanged since the 2026-09-23 fix was proposed.

Replace with: You've done something for the family, and a small criticism is still bothering you days later. (Move the Ch7 link after L11.)

Q043 · 33 · med

Problem: Raises cruelty only to dismiss it.

Replace with: 'She's seeing her side, the same way you've only seen yours a hundred times over.'

Q086 · 19 · low

Problem: Management and therapy vocabulary close to the avoided 'emotional labor' (backlog, still present).

Replace with: panel: She remembers the appointments and plans what the kids need. **OR** *slopreader:* 'She remembers the appointments and plans what the kids need.'

Q087 · 27 · low

Problem: A crowd foil introducing the quote.

Replace with: Delete the sentence.

Q088 · 57 · low

Problem: A signpost line sits between the last section and the closing line, making a double ending.

Replace with: Move to the end of L55's paragraph or cut it; end on L59.

Ch9

Q089 · 25 · low

Problem: Repeats line 17's back-reference.

Replace with: Delete the sentence.

Q090 · 27 · low

Problem: Re-lists Gottman's four signs (already in Ch3) and repeats Ch4's disdain-to-

contempt chain.

Replace with: Contempt, the warning sign John Gottman found matters most, is what disappointment turns into when it never gets spoken and never gets addressed.

Q091 · 43 · low

Problem: Windup (backlog, still present).

Replace with: panel: Delete; begin with ’Epictetus, in his handbook the *Enchiridion*...’ **OR** *slopreader:* Delete; begin ’Epictetus, in his handbook the *Enchiridion*, tells his student…’

Ch10

Q007 · 147 · HIGH

Problem: The refrain ’You hold it anyway.’ directly follows the safety sentence, so it reads as ’stay in harm’s way’.

Replace with: panel: Move ’You hold it anyway.’ (L147) to directly after ’Her crossing a line doesn’t give you permission to cross it too.’ (L134-135); end the tier on ’Holding your own standard doesn’t require staying in harm’s way.’ **OR** *slopreader:* Move ’You hold it anyway.’ to follow line 135 (’…doesn’t give you permission to cross it too. You hold it anyway.’) and end the beat at ’…doesn’t require staying in harm’s way.’

Q047 · 224 · med

Problem: One of six crowd foils in Ch10, the heaviest cluster in the book.

Replace with: 224: ’It’s easy to hand that job to your wife.’ 50: ’If you’ve never answered that question out loud, that’s exactly why the rule folds…’ 121: ’The third one is the hardest.’

Q092 · 6 · low

Problem: Near-verbatim repeat of Ch2's introduction of Epictetus.

Replace with: Epictetus, the former slave who became a teacher, wrote a handbook, the *Enchiridion*... (merge into L7).

Q094 · 84 · low

Problem: The Pillemer paragraph is orphaned and connects to nothing.

Replace with: way two people speak to each other all came up. Those are the three places the lines in this chapter live.

Q095 · 273 · low

Problem: A comma splice in the chapter's last line.

Replace with: You're not holding any of this to win. You're holding it because your marriage is what's on the other side of it.

Ch11

Q050 · 77 · med

Problem: A liability-voice disclaimer breaks the guide's register.

Replace with: Delete the sentence.

Q051 · 119 · med

Problem: Turns Ch1's four virtues into five qualities, and L121's self-control sentence already covers trying again.

Replace with: panel: Delete the sentence. **OR** *slopreader:* Cut the Patience sentence and fold it into Self-control: 'Self-control means giving the conversation time and keeping your tone respectful when her answer disappoints you.'

Q052 · 131 · med

Problem: Part II has no closing beat; Ch5 closes Part I but Ch11 ends on a complaint

script with no handoff to the Sun.

Replace with: panel: After L131 add a short Part close, e.g. ’Part II asked whether you can carry the weight without resentment, scorekeeping or silence. Part III asks whether she can feel it: whether you bring warmth on purpose, before anyone asks.’ **OR** *panel:* Say the small thing while it’s still small, so the rest of the evening can belong to the two of you again.

Q096 · 3 · low

Problem: Repeats Ch1’s lying-in-bed replay staging.

Replace with: panel: The next morning, on the drive in, you’re still explaining to yourself why you stayed quiet. **OR** *slopreader:* ’The next morning, on the drive in, you’re still explaining to yourself why you stayed quiet.’

Q097 · 27 · low

Problem: ’Tolerate’ three times frames her friendships as something he endures.

Replace with: I’m glad she has real friends, and those friendships matter more to me than the comments.

Q098 · 113 · low

Problem: ’You can [A] and still [B]’ appears four times in Ch11 and is the later chapters’ signature shape; the count is for voice_check.py to confirm.

Replace with: Ch11 117: ’Staying calm in an argument doesn’t mean you’ve started the discussion that needs to happen.’; Ch11 29: ’Disliking part of the visit doesn’t mean you don’t want to go.’

Ch12

Q099 · 7 · low

Problem: An unclear dismissal of the weekly-date advice.

Replace with: I don’t know where that number came from. What counts is that you actually go.

Q101 · 51 · low

Problem: The reader has to rebuild who trades what.

Replace with: ’Trying to win her favor doesn’t mean expecting payment for it.’

Q102 · 83 · low

Problem: Talks down to a reader the audience file says already knows Marcus.

Replace with: Delete the sentence.

Q103 · 87 · low

Problem: The close mixes ’necessary things’ with ’muscle’.

Replace with: ’She’s been waiting to be one of the necessary things, and you can put her on the list tonight.’

Ch13

Q104 · 3 · low

Problem: Reuses Ch1’s key term ’gap’ for a new meaning (attention), the same drift fixed in Ch6.

Replace with: ’The difference is small enough to miss for years.’

Q105 · 23 · low

Problem: Ch12 and Ch13 both centre on ’the date’ (deferred in inbox 112).

Replace with: **The Saturday you can’t plan.**

Q106 · 61 · low

Problem: Ends on the opening's failure (the phone) rather than on her; the 2026-10-02 warmth fix was not applied.

Replace with: She's still telling you who she is, a little at a time, and tonight you get to listen.

Ch14

Q057 · 73 · med

Problem: The chapter ends on a moral after a stronger image close.

Replace with: Delete line 73; the chapter closes on 'Slow down enough to taste them.'

Q108 · 11 · low

Problem: A muddled comparison.

Replace with: panel: Her worry can annoy me, but in her eyes, being late is just as annoying. **OR** *slopreader:* 'That's who she is.

It can annoy me, and my lateness annoys her just as much.’

Q109 · 21 · low

Problem: A study of schoolchildren interrupts the author’s warmest domestic paragraph.

Replace with: Cut it, or move it to an endnote.

Q111 · 31 · low

Problem: Invites the misreading ’tell her I noticed someone else’ (warmth review item, softened but still present).

Replace with: When you catch yourself comparing, look back at the whole of the woman in front of you.

Ch15

Q113 · 15 · low

Problem: A garbled sentence.

Replace with: panel: You keep using whatever works in the moment. **OR** *slopreader:* ’Over the years we’d each learned which answers worked in an argument, and we kept using them.’

Q114 · 71 · low

Problem: A double ending after the author-confirmed ah-ha (L69), and the third ’roll up your sleeves’.

Replace with: Delete L71 and end on L69.